

StoryForge AI

User Manual

From Solution Design Document to Azure DevOps work items — automatically, consistently, and grounded in your own codebase.

Version 1.0

1. Introduction

StoryForge AI is an internal tool that turns a Solution Design Document (SDD) into a complete, ready-to-create Azure DevOps (ADO) work item hierarchy: one **Epic** and **User Story** per feature described in the SDD, each broken down into detailed **Dev Tasks** and matching **Unit Test Tasks**.

Unlike a generic AI writing assistant, StoryForge AI grounds everything it generates in your own organization's material: your existing user manuals and your actual source code (Spring Boot services, Angular frontend, and any legacy JS/jQuery screens). This means the Dev Tasks it produces describe real affected components, real API contracts, and real database considerations — not generic boilerplate.

Who this manual is for:

- Business Analysts who write or receive Solution Design Documents and need a consistent, thorough breakdown of work for delivery teams.
- Project Managers / Delivery Leads who need Epics and Stories created in ADO without manually writing every Dev Task and Unit Test Task by hand.

What this manual does *not* cover: installing or configuring the StoryForge AI application itself. That setup is handled once by your administrator/IT team — see the project's technical README for that.

2. Before You Start (One-Time Setup)

Before StoryForge AI can generate accurate, grounded stories, it needs to “learn” your environment. This is a **one-time setup step performed by an administrator** — you do not need to do this yourself, but it's useful to understand what it means:

- **User manuals are indexed** — existing system/user documentation (PDFs) is loaded so the AI can reference documented behavior.
- **The codebase is indexed** — your application's source code is scanned so the AI can reference real services, components, and database entities when describing affected components and API contracts.

This indexing only needs to be refreshed when the manuals or the codebase change meaningfully (e.g. a new release, a new module). If you notice the generated stories reference outdated behavior, ask your administrator to re-run the indexing step.

3. Key Terms

Term	Meaning
SDD	Solution Design Document — the PDF you upload describing the feature/change to be built.

PPM Number / Name	Your organization's project/portfolio tracking identifiers, attached to every work item created.
System Name	The name of the application/system the SDD applies to.
Epic	The top-level ADO work item representing one distinct feature from the SDD.
User Story	Sits under the Epic; describes the feature from a user's perspective with acceptance criteria.
Dev Task	A concrete implementation task under the User Story, with technical approach, affected components, AP
Unit Test Task	A test task paired 1:1 with each Dev Task, describing test scenarios, test data, mocks, and assertions.
Clarification	A question StoryForge AI asks when the SDD is ambiguous in a way that would affect the generated wor
Review Mode	An optional setting that pauses the process so a human can edit the generated stories before they're cre
ADO	Azure DevOps — where the final Epic/Story/Task hierarchy is created.

4. Submitting a New Assessment

From the Dashboard, click **New Assessment** to open the submission form.

Step 1 — Fill in the project details

- **PPM Number** — your project's tracking number.
- **PPM Name** — a short descriptive name for the project.
- **System Name** — the application/system this change applies to.

Step 2 — Upload your Solution Design Document

Attach the SDD as a PDF file. This is the document StoryForge AI will analyze.

Step 3 — Decide whether you want to review before creation

Toggle **Review Mode** on if you want to see and edit the generated stories before they're created in ADO. Leave it off if you trust the AI's output to flow straight through to ADO automatically.

Recommendation: keep Review Mode on the first few times you use StoryForge AI for a given system, until you've confirmed the generated stories match your expectations.

Step 4 — Submit and wait

Click **Submit**. You'll be taken to the Status page for this job, where you can track progress in real time. The first stage (Analyzing) reads your document and retrieves relevant context — this can take anywhere from a few seconds to a couple of minutes depending on document size.

5. Answering Clarification Questions

Sometimes the SDD is ambiguous in ways that would directly affect the generated work items. When this happens, StoryForge AI pauses and asks you targeted questions instead of guessing. It only asks about four specific categories:

- Undefined status values or error codes
- Missing API endpoint paths or payload structures
- Unspecified middleware queue/topic names
- Implied database changes that aren't confirmed elsewhere

If clarification is needed, you'll be redirected to the Clarify page automatically. Answer each question in plain text and click **Submit Answers**. Generation will then resume using your answers to resolve the ambiguity.

If the SDD is unambiguous in these four categories, this step is skipped entirely and the job proceeds straight to story generation — most well-specified SDDs won't trigger any clarification questions.

6. Reviewing Generated Stories (Review Mode only)

If you enabled Review Mode, you'll be redirected to the Review page once generation finishes. Here you'll see every generated Epic/User Story, each with its Dev Tasks and Unit Test Tasks fully expanded.

What to check

- Does the Epic title and User Story accurately represent the intended feature?
- Are the Acceptance Criteria complete and testable?
- Do the Dev Tasks reference the correct affected layers (frontend/backend/middleware/database)? A layer marked “N/A” should have a one-sentence justification — if that justification looks wrong, edit it.
- Does each Dev Task have a matching Unit Test Task covering the same functionality?

You can edit any field directly on this page. Once you're satisfied, click **Approve & Create in ADO**. The approved (possibly edited) stories are what actually get created as work items — nothing is created until you approve.

7. Tracking Status & Viewing Results

The Status page shows a step-by-step progress indicator and refreshes automatically. The possible stages are:

Stage	What's happening
Analyzing	Reading the SDD and retrieving related manuals/codebase context.
Clarifying	Waiting on your answers to ambiguity questions (skipped if none needed).
Generating	Claude is drafting the Epics, User Stories, Dev Tasks, and Unit Test Tasks.
Reviewing	Waiting on your approval (only if Review Mode is on).
Creating	Creating the Epic → User Story → Task hierarchy in Azure DevOps.
Done	Finished. Scroll down to see the ADO Work Items table with direct links.
Error	Something failed. See the error message(s) listed on the page and contact your administrator if it's not self-e

Once a job reaches **Done**, the ADO Work Items table lists every Epic and User Story created, with a link straight to each item in Azure DevOps so you can jump directly to assigning, estimating, or

scheduling the work.

8. Understanding What Gets Created in ADO

Every feature StoryForge AI identifies in your SDD becomes this hierarchy:

Epic → **User Story** → **Dev Tasks** (implementation) + **Unit Test Tasks** (one per Dev Task, same index)

Each Dev Task includes

- **User Story** restated for that specific task's scope
- **Acceptance Criteria** — Given/When/Then statements
- **Technical Approach** — ordered implementation steps
- **Affected Components** — frontend, backend, middleware, database (or “N/A” with justification)
- **API Contract** — endpoint, request/response shapes, status codes (when applicable)
- **Business Rules** — explicit rules the implementation must enforce
- **Error Handling** — known failure scenarios and expected behavior

Each Unit Test Task includes

- **Test Objective** — what the test proves, tied to its matching Dev Task
- **Test Scenarios** — happy path, negative, and edge cases
- **Test Data** — example valid and invalid payloads
- **Mock Setup** — what dependencies to mock and how
- **Assertions** — concrete pass/fail checks

StoryForge AI never invents specific file or class names. Affected components are always described by their logical role (e.g. “the customer validation service”), so the output stays accurate even as your codebase evolves.

9. Frequently Asked Questions

Why didn't I get any clarification questions?

Your SDD was clear enough across all four ambiguity categories StoryForge AI checks. This is common for well-specified documents and is not a sign of anything being skipped.

Why does a Dev Task say a layer is “N/A”?

That layer genuinely isn't affected by that task, per the SDD and the retrieved codebase context. A short justification is always included next to it — if that justification looks wrong, flag it during Review.

The Status page shows “Error” — what do I do?

Check the error message(s) listed on the page. Common causes are a malformed/unreadable SDD PDF or a temporary issue reaching the AI or Azure DevOps. If re-submitting doesn't resolve it, contact your administrator with the Job ID.

Can I still edit stories after they're created in ADO?

Yes — once items exist in ADO, edit them there as you would any other work item. StoryForge AI's review step is your chance to edit *before* creation; ADO itself is the source of truth afterward.

How long does an assessment take?

Typically a few minutes end-to-end when Review Mode is off and no clarification is needed. Review Mode and clarification pauses add however long it takes a human to respond, since the job waits for you.

Can I submit the same SDD twice?

Yes. Each submission is an independent job with its own Job ID and its own set of generated/created work items — nothing is deduplicated against prior runs.

10. Getting Help

If you run into an issue not covered here — unexpected output, a stuck job, or anything that looks wrong — contact your StoryForge AI administrator with the Job ID shown on the Status page. That ID lets them look up exactly what happened during your assessment.